

Dugong

Dugong dugon

thick bristles on
snout used to
detect food



The dugong, a close relative of the elephant, is often called the sea cow, because it feeds almost exclusively on seagrass in shallow coastal tropical waters. Dugongs have torpedo-shaped bodies, broad heads, stubby flippers, and fleshy, bristled lips.

When dugongs dive, their valved nostrils seal themselves off. However, these large mammals can stay underwater only for about three minutes. Adult dugongs have few natural enemies because of their size and dense bones, though crocodiles, sharks, and killer whales attack calves and juveniles. Dugongs do not

mate until they are at least six years old, and only one calf is produced every three to seven years. Born in shallow water, after a 14-month gestation, the calf is immediately helped to the surface for its first breath by its mother.

Dugongs can live up to 70 years. However, their low reproductive rate, the loss of seagrass due to human activity, collisions with boats, drownings from fish net entanglements, and hunting mean that dugong populations are in decline. Today the largest numbers are concentrated around Australia's Great Barrier Reef.

- ↔ 7–11ft (2–3.3m)
- ⚖ 550–1,257lb (250–570kg)
- ⊗ Vulnerable
- 🌿 Seagrass, algae
- 🏠



E. Africa, W., S., and SE. Asia,
Australia, Pacific Islands



◀ KEEPING COMPANY

Dugongs are often flanked by golden trevallies. These brightly colored fish feed on the creatures dugongs disturb when grazing.

▷ MOTHER AND CALF

Dugongs communicate with each other using trills, whistles, barks, and chirps, each at a different frequency and amplitude.



Ribbontail stingray

Taeniura lymma

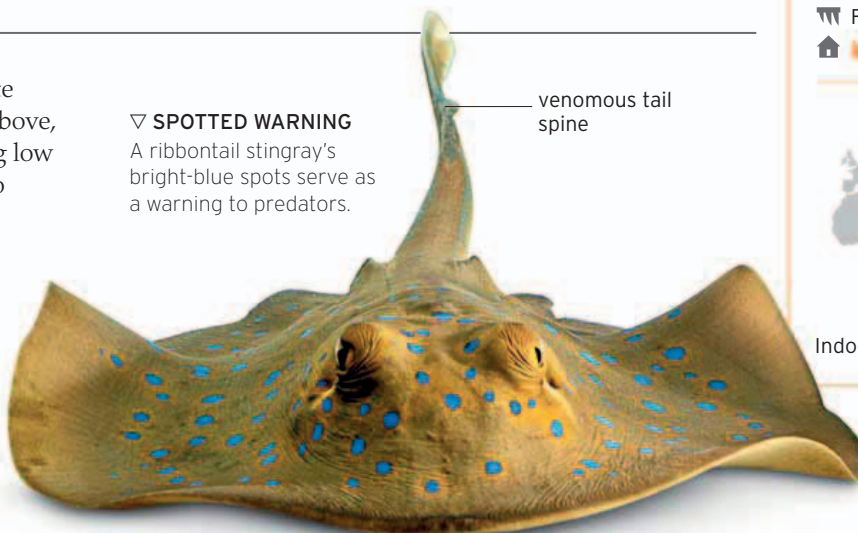
Viewed from below, a ribbontail stingray's white underside disappears into sunlit waters; from above, its speckled back blends into coral reefs. During low tide, stingrays seek shelter in reefs, moving into shallower water to feed as the tide rises.

A ribbontail stingray's mouth contains numerous tooth rows arranged in plates, ideal for crushing crustacean shells. Rays can sense food by detecting the prey's electrical field. They have few natural predators; only the hammerhead shark is known to eat them. They breed in late spring and summer. A female delivers up to seven live pups that hatch from eggs inside her body.

▽ SPOTTED WARNING

A ribbontail stingray's bright-blue spots serve as a warning to predators.

venomous tail
spine



- ↔ Up to 28 in (70cm)
- ⚖ Not known
- ⊗ Near threatened
- 🐟 Fish, crustaceans
- 🏠



Indo-Pacific Oceans